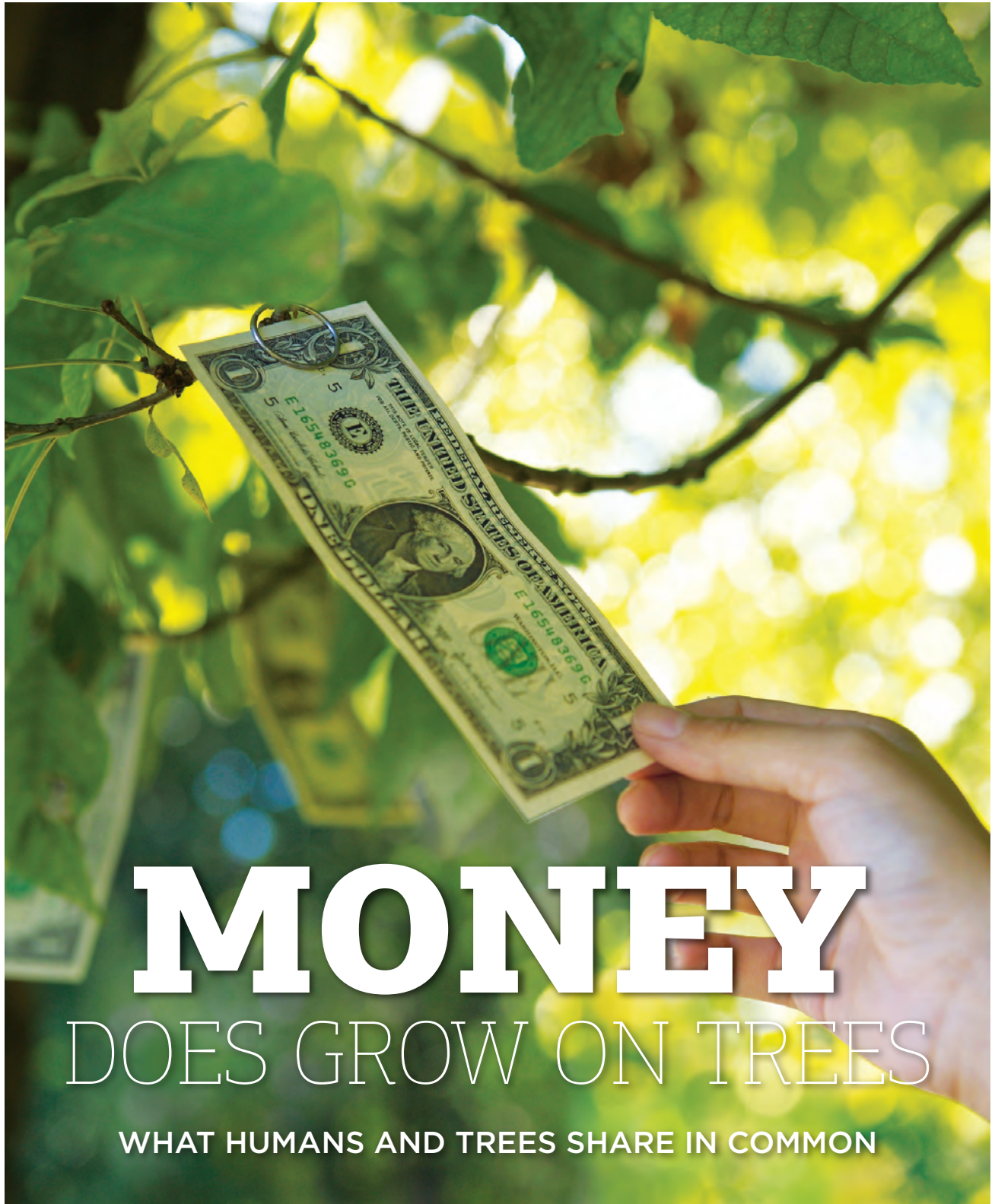




MONEY

DOES GROW ON TREES

WHAT HUMANS AND TREES SHARE IN COMMON

Contributing Shluchim: **Rabbi Zalman Grossbaum, Rabbi Moshe Herson, Rabbi Sholom Lipsker**

WHAT FUNDRAISING IS NOT

Money doesn't grow on trees," goes the saying. But for the fundraiser it most definitely grows on human beings. And one of the many things humans and trees have in common, is that they both need a lot of nurturing before they bare fruits.

There is not as much in common between ATM machines and human beings.

When we say "nurture", we are referring to the buzz word: relationship. A deep connection between schnorer and gvir is the recipe for a good nidava — and even more importantly, is the best way to boost up the yiddishkeit level as well.

To cultivate relationships takes time. This might be a hard pill to swallow for the many of us who (think that we) don't have the time to nurture them. Relationships are for veteran shluchim with a stable (?) income and lifestyle, but we need the money now.

In the words of **Rabbi Sholom Lipsker**, Shliach in Bal Harbor Florida: "In my early years, even though we had many opportunities to build our organizations' programs with the new contacts that were being introduced to me, instead of utilizing the opportunity to meet new contacts for my primary purpose, to imbue them with spiritual content, and eventually get them involved in the program, I didn't have time for it. I was so pressed against the wall, there were so many emergencies, that the only thought that came to mind as soon as I met these people was how to ask them for some money."

"As a result of the pressing emergencies, in most cases I was not able to get from people the kinds of gifts and potential that they were capable of giving. This is because I didn't have a chance to cultivate their relationship. I failed to help them to really, deeply understand and appreciate the kind of programs we were doing."

The fundraiser who doesn't have the investment perspective, might play the nebach game, where he pulls up in a shmate of a car, pours his heart out about

how he doesn't have food on the table, and begs for salvation. He might fulfill his short term need, but in the long term he lost, for no donor wants to invest in an organization whose director is a 'lo yuzlach'. However, were he to first invest in the relationship, become a true friend, identify with his ideals, and build trust between them, then the tree would bear fruit for years to come.

WHAT FUNDRAISING IS

"The first advice I would give to any young rabbi," offers **Rabbi Moshe Herson**, Head Shliach of New Jersey, "Is that as soon as you arrive in a city, try to create bridges and relationships. Build personal connections with people. Appeal to their Judaism and their spirituality, and reawaken that pintele Yid. Surround yourself with a human wall of friends. You will see that, G-d willing, you will never go wrong with that."

So as it turns out, donors are human beings as well. Surprise! And we must remember that the way to their wallet is through the neshama, the Pintele Yid. When we ignite the neshama, and when we awaken a passion in the heart for Jewish causes and the work that we do, then the chances of a 'YES! Whatever you say rabbi!' rises tenfold.

Says **Rabbi Grossbaum**, Shliach in

Livingston NJ: "We must see our moissad as part of the community, and we must educate the community to look at the moissad as theirs. When they donate to the moissad they are really donating to themselves and their community. They are investing in their own future. It's not my moissad — it's *our* moissad!"

From this perspective, we are each playing different roles in the partnership which will guarantee the future of the Jewish community:

The rabbi prepares sermons, harasses sleepy members to come to minyan, teaches Torah and, during yomim tovim and camp, runs around like a chicken without a head. That's his role. The rebbetzin cooks endlessly, smiles through all that comes her way and fits in a class or two every day. And finally, the lay leaders learn about Yiddishkeit, crack a good joke with the rabbi, compliment the rebbetzin on the great food, and support the center in order to be in touch with their soul and to ensure that their children get a Jewish education and marry Jewish.

IN SUMMARY:

There are many tips in fundraising, and each shliach would do well to pick up a book or two on the subject. They will teach you which of the donor's eyes to look at when you ask for money, and what tone of voice to conclude the pitch with. Altz gut un fein. But those are merely techniques that teach you how to pick the fruit off the tree.

How do you get to the stage of picking the fruit? What are the seed, stump, branches, and leaves which produce fruit year after year? Relationships.

Happy harvesting! 

FUNDRAISING NUGGET:

"If there is one thing that I must pinpoint as a vital element in the trust between donor and shliach, it is transparency," says Rabbi Grossbaum. "The donor must know where his money went. How did the Jewish community gain from his donation?"